

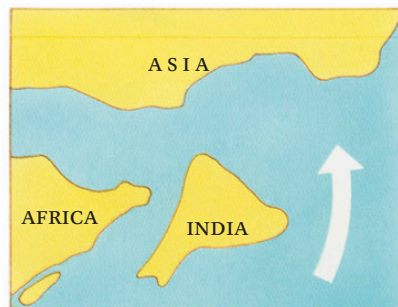
# ASIA

ASIA IS THE LARGEST CONTINENT on the planet. Much of northern, central, and southwest Asia has a cold, dry climate, with harsh deserts, dry grasslands, and frozen forests where few birds can survive. Many birds are forced to migrate south during colder seasons. The warm, rainy, tropical lands of Southeast Asia are, however, home to a spectacular variety of birds including pheasants, babblers, flycatchers, warblers, and thrushes. Some birds, such as the golden-fronted leafbird, the great argus pheasant, and the rhinoceros hornbill are not found anywhere else in the world.

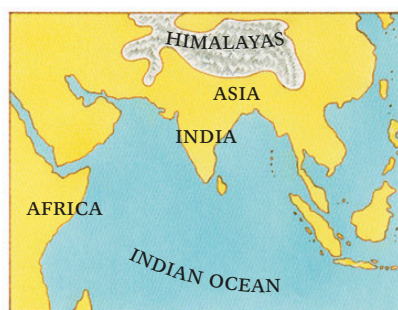
## India on the move

Over millions of years, continental drift has caused India to move into different positions on the globe.

**About 200 million years ago,** India was attached to Africa, Australia, and Antarctica. But it split away on its own and slowly began to drift northward toward Asia (right).



**About 60–40 million years ago,** India crashed into Asia, pushing up land from under the sea to create the gigantic folds of land that form the Himalayan Mountains. India is still pushing into Asia at a rate of about 0.6 miles (1 km) every 100,000 years.



To the west, Asia is attached to Europe and Africa and some of the birds are the same as, or similar to, birds in these continents. To the south, the islands of Southeast Asia form a series of stepping stones along which birds can move to and from New Guinea and Australia.

About half the world's population lives in Asia. They have made major changes to the land and plant life across the continent. Birds are increasingly threatened by the spread of cities and by forest destruction. Unless birds can adapt to an urban lifestyle, they have nowhere to live when their natural homes are destroyed.

## Climate and landscape

The great Asian mountain chains, such as the Karakoram, Pamirs, and Himalayas, cut across Asia from east to west, separating the warmer, wetter lands of India and Southeast Asia from the cooler, drier lands of central Asia. Southeast Asia consists mainly of thousands of islands, many of which were formed by volcanoes erupting through the seabed.

## AMAZING BIRDS OF ASIA



**Black woodpecker**  
(*Dryocopus martius*)

### Loud woodpecker

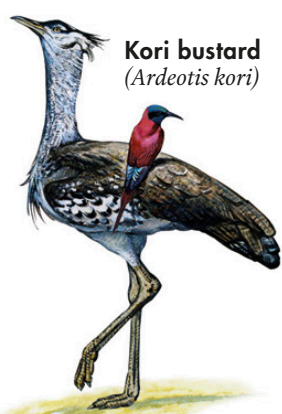
This enormous woodpecker can be heard hammering at tree trunks from up to 1.12 miles (1.8 km) away.

### Quick chicks

The chicks of the Cabot's tragopan are some of the quickest to fly after hatching. They grow all their flight feathers within 24 hours of hatching and can flutter up into the trees immediately.

### Heaviest flier

The Kori bustard is the world's heaviest flying bird. Males can weigh up to 42 lb (19 kg).



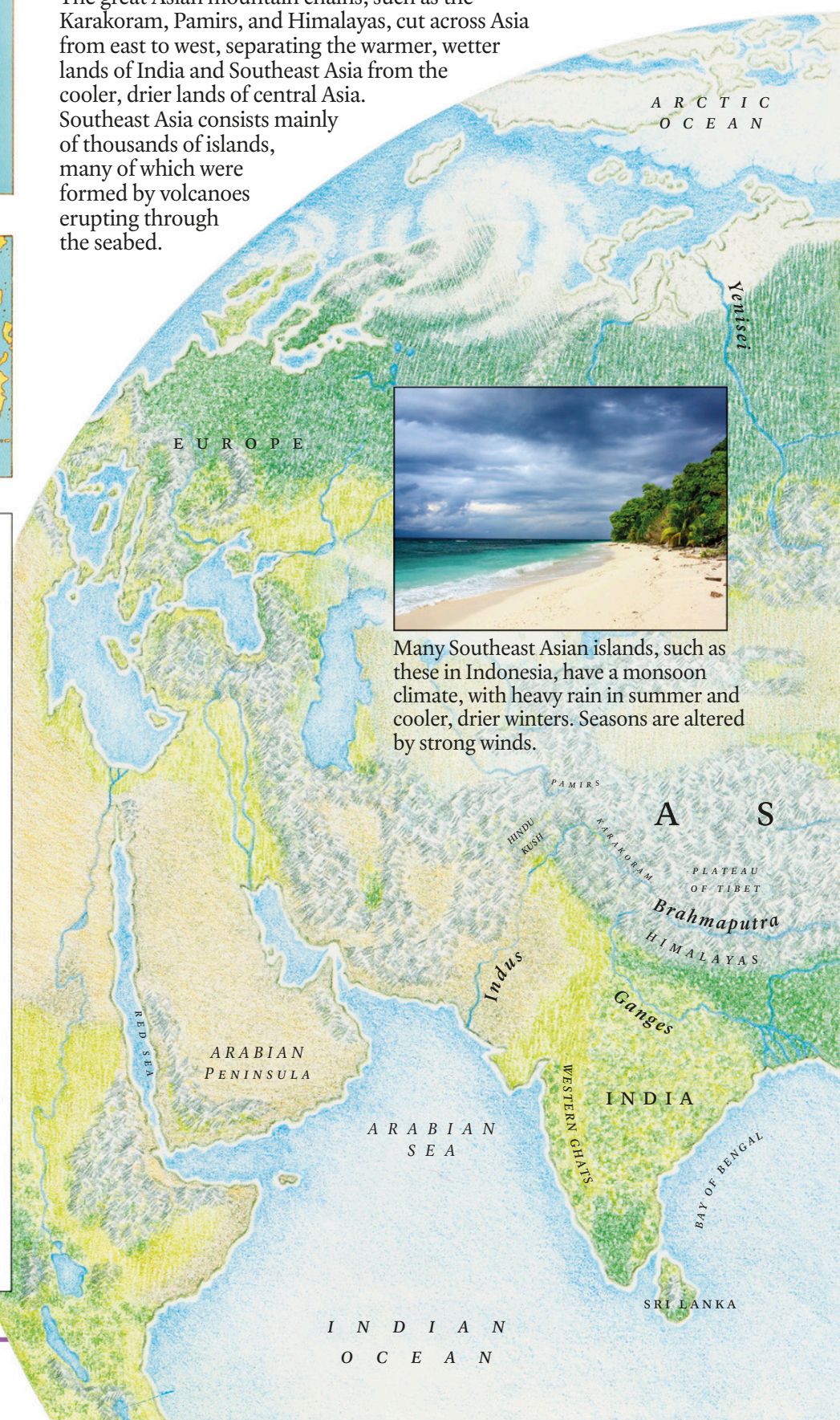
**Kori bustard**  
(*Ardeotis kori*)

### Heaviest head

The helmeted hornbill has a solid ivory casque on top of its bill, giving it the heaviest bill of any bird.

### Biggest tail

The crested argus pheasant has the longest feathers and the longest and largest tail in the world. A male's tail feathers can reach 5 ft 8 in (1 m 73 cm) long and 5 in (13 cm) wide.



Many Southeast Asian islands, such as these in Indonesia, have a monsoon climate, with heavy rain in summer and cooler, drier winters. Seasons are altered by strong winds.